Many were struck by the contrast between the rebels' ragged appearance and their courage. A woman who saw the Confederate Army of Northern Virginia on the march in late summer 1862, described the "gaunt starvation that looked from their cavernous eyes" and commented: "That they could march or fight at all seems incredible." Yet these were the soldiers who checked the Union forces at Antietam.

A HOPELESS CAUSE

The Confederate soldier's experience of war was of a shortage of everything: boots, clothes, blankets, tents, food, cartridges, pay. Many were reduced to marching barefoot unless they could "liberate" some Union footwear. Faced with the North's overwhelming superiority, the South had little choice but to rely upon the attacking spirit of its soldiers. It cost them dearly and could not win the war. But the Confederate soldier emerged with honour, if little else.



Confederate weaponry
The standard infantry weapon was the rifle-musket. The Enfield was imported in large numbers from manufacturers in Britain.

Confederate uniform
Infantrymen fought in a huge variety of different colours, including grey, blue, and "butternut", shown here in this replica of a uniform of 1862.

"A MOTLEY-LOOKING CREW, BUT THEY FIGHT LIKE DEVILS."

UNION SOLDIER ON HIS CONFEDERATE ENEMIES